

Finiteness and clause size: The case of Bulgarian *da*-constructions from a formal and diachronic perspective

This paper addresses a central question in syntactic theory: what is the formal relationship between finiteness and clause size? Traditional approaches equate finiteness with morphological tense and agreement, while more recent work has argued that finiteness reflects structural properties of the clause, in particular the presence of functional projections such as TP and CP (Chomsky 1981, Stowell 1982, Wurmbrand 2014, Wurmbrand et al. 2020). Bulgarian (Bg) provides a particularly revealing testing ground for this question because it lacks infinitival morphology and instead employs morphologically finite *da*-constructions in contexts cross-linguistically associated with non-finite complementation (Krapova 2001, 2025, Sočanac 2017).

We argue that Bg *da*-clauses demonstrate that finiteness, at its core, is a syntactic phenomenon, which is fundamentally determined by clause size, independently from the overt morphological marking of (non)finiteness. Specifically, we show that Bg *da*-complements instantiate three structurally distinct configurations corresponding to different positions on the Implicational Complementation Hierarchy from Wurmbrand & Lohninger (2023): (i) event complements (small vP structures involving restructuring), (ii) situation complements (control TP structures), and (iii) propositional complements (full CP structures). These structures differ systematically across a range of grammatical areas, including temporal interpretation, subject licensing, and syntactic transparency more generally. These contrasts follow directly from the differences in terms of the size of functional structure associated with different complements.

The first class consists of restructuring complements selected by modal and aspectual predicates such as *moga* ‘can’, *trjabva* ‘must’, and *započvam* ‘begin’. We argue that these complements lack TP and CP projections and correspond to bare vP structures. They exhibit temporal co-reference/identity with the matrix clause (banning the use of temporal markers that conflict with the matrix tense) (1), strict exhaustive control (2), as well as monoclausality diagnostics such as transparency for passivization or idiom preservation.

- (1) Vasil *trjabvaše / započna da uči* [včera / *utre].
V. had-to.IMP began.3SG PRT study.3SG yesterday tomorrow
(2) Ivan *trjabvaše / započna da [raboti / *rabotim zaedno / *Marija raboti]*.
I. had-to.IMP began.3SG PRT work.3SG work.1PL together M. works

Crucially, the fact that these complements do not license independent subjects or any independent tense content indicates the absence of an independent finiteness domain in their underlying structure. Hence, despite the fact that they feature morphologically finite verb forms, these complements instantiate the smallest clausal size available in language, i.e. they only project a vP domain.

The second class consists of complements selected by subject-control and object-control predicates such as *rešavam* ‘decide’, *vážnamerjavam* ‘intend’, or *ubeždavam* ‘convince’, among others. These complements differ from their restructuring counterparts in allowing partial control and split antecedents (3), properties widely taken to diagnose the presence of a structural subject position (Landau 2013). At the same time, they impose strict future orientation and prohibit independent tense interpretation (4).

- (3) a. Marija *vážnamerjava / reši* [PRO *da izbjaga / izbjagame zaedno*].
M. intend.3SG decided.3SG PRT run-away.3SG run-away.1PL together
b. *Predložih na Marija da otidem zaedno na kino*.
suggested.1SG to M. PRT go.1PL together to cinema
(6) Marija [*vážnamerjava/otkazva*] [PRO *da dade poveče informacija dnes / utre / *včera*].
M. intend.3SG refuse.3SG PRT give.3SG more information today tomorrow yesterday

We argue that these complements project a TP layer but lack a CP projection. Their temporal interpretation reflects the presence of a defective T head, which introduces temporal structure but lacks full referential independence. This analysis captures the hybrid status of these complements, which exhibit biclausality but remain structurally deficient relative to propositional complements.

The third class consists of complements selected by propositional attitude predicates such as *nadjavam* ‘hope’ and *vjarvam* ‘believe’. These complements allow overt subjects (5), independent tense interpretation (6), and full referential autonomy, indicating full CP structure.

- (5) *Nadjavam se / vjarvam* [Ivan *da nameri pătja lesno*].
hope.1SG believe.1SG I. PRT find.3SG way.DET easily
(6) *Ivan se nadjava / vjarva* [*pro_i da e pristignal ošte včera / pro_i pristigne utre.*].
I. hope.3SG believe.3SG PRT is arrive.PART already yesterday arrive.3SG tomorrow

The contrast between these complements and smaller *da*-clauses demonstrates that independent tense and subject licensing correlate with the presence of higher functional structure rather than with morphological tense/agreement marking (given that the latter is present with all complements exemplified in [1-6]).

In the second part of the paper, we extend this analysis to diachrony and argue that the historical loss of the infinitive (Inf) in Bg reflects structural reanalysis driven by clause size. We show that Inf was replaced by *da*-constructions first in structurally larger complements and only later in structurally smaller restructuring contexts. Thus, in Old Bg (cca. 9th-11th century), small vP complements only featured Inf (7) while TP complements (particularly those involving object control) involved competing use of Inf and *da*-complements (although Inf remained predominant in the cases of subject control) (8).

- (7) a. *nača emu dary mnogo dajati.* b. *ne trěbujutŭ otiti.*
 began.3SG he.DAT gifts many give.INF NEG must.3PL leave.INF
 (Vita Constantini, 9th c.) (Codex Marianus, 11th c.)

- (8) a. *Moljaaxŭ i da ne povělitŭ imŭ vŭ bezdŭnŭ itŭ.*
 begged.3PL he.ACC PRT NEG tell.3SG they.DAT to abyss go.INF
 b. *hoštemŭ ot tebe znamenŭ viděti.*
 want.1PL from you sign see.INF
 (Codex Marianus, 11th c.)

During the Middle Bg period (cca. 12th-14th century), *da*-constructions continued to spread at the expense of Inf across all types of situation/TP complements, including those involving subject control, where we begin to observe both Inf and *da* (9), but the use of Inf in small event/vP complements remained stable (10).

- (9) a. *hoteše pogubiti menelauša* b. *hotěhŭ da pogubatŭ asileeša*
 wanted.IMP.3PL execute.INF Menelaus wanted.AOR.3PL PRT execute.INF Achilles
 (Tale of Troy, 14th c.)

- (10) a. *i načāšŭ proricati* b. *ne ima vŭlěsti vŭ selo*
 and began.3PL divining NEG should.3SG enter.INF in village
 (Tale of Troy) (Wallachian charters, 15th-16th c.)

vP-type complements were the last to replace Inf with Subj (from the end of the Middle Bg period onwards).

We propose that this full replacement of Inf by *da*-clauses resulted from the reanalysis of the item *da* as a lower functional head, allowing it to merge in reduced clausal environments previously restricted to infinitives. As a result of this reanalysis, *da* became contiguous with the embedded verb in modern Bg (11a), which was not the case in Old/Middle Bg, where we observed various types of syntactic constituents intervening between *da* and the embedded verb (11b-c).

- (11) a. *Iskam [Ivan] da [*Ivan] dojde [Ivan].*
 want.1SG I. PRT I. come.3SG I.
 b. *priněse děti da ročě vŭzložitŭ na nje.*
 brought.3PL children PRT hands put.3SG on them
 c. *něsmŭ bo dostoinŭ da podŭ krovŭ moj vŭnideši.*
 NEG.be.1SG PRT worthy PRT under roof my enter.2SG
 (Codex Marianus)

This change represents a downward expansion in the structural distribution of *da*, consistent with general principles of syntactic reanalysis targeting functional heads.

The diachronic developments just described provide independent support for the clause size hypothesis. If finiteness were purely morphological, no principled explanation would exist for the observed order of replacement of Inf by *da*-constructions. However, if complement types differ structurally, the historical sequence follows naturally. Larger complements already contained the necessary functional structure to host *da*, while smaller complements required reanalysis of the particle's structural position. The latter was a more recent diachronic development (likely a contact-induced Balkan-sprachbund innovation), which is why the use of Inf in event-type vP complements was maintained for longest.

The analysis has broader theoretical implications as well. First, it supports approaches that treat clause size as a fundamental parameter governing syntactic behavior. Second, it provides evidence that control, restructuring, and finiteness reflect a unified structural hierarchy rather than distinct lexical phenomena. Third, it shows that diachronic change targets functional structure and can reveal underlying syntactic organization. More generally, Bg facts argue for a theory in which finiteness emerges from structural configuration rather than from morphological marking. Clause size determines temporal interpretation, subject licensing, and syntactic independence, while morphology may fail to transparently reflect these distinctions. Bg thus provides crucial evidence that the syntax of finiteness must be defined in structural terms.

References

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